mein Modi ka craze ho gaya hai!' (There's a craze for Modi among the people), said Sushil Modi, almost apologetically.

It was a 'craze' that the BJP was determined to build on. From the day Nitish ended the alliance, the entire Sangh Parivar machinery was put on alert in Bihar. Winning Bihar became a prestige issue for Team Modi. 'If there was one north Indian state where Modiji was taking a daily personal interest, it was Bihar. It was almost as if he wanted to teach Nitish a lesson,' a BJP leader told me.

Angered by Nitish's public challenge, the upper castes had already firmly consolidated behind the BJP. The challenge was to break into Bihar's complex backward-caste matrix. When I pointed this out to Ravi Shankar Prasad, the BJP leader from Bihar, he smiled: 'Don't forget the biggest backward-caste leader in the country, Narendra Modi, is with us!' In every Bihar speech, Modi never missed an opportunity to stress his caste background.

Local BJP and RSS leaders had already organized caste-specific events in the state to break into the state's complex caste matrix—a convention for Dhanuks and Keots, a special programme for Koeris. There was a special push towards reaching out even to Yadavs, who, it was felt, were tiring of Lalu's brand of politics. The party roped in Upendra Kushwaha, a backward-caste leader who was once a Nitish aide. By February 2014, they would even have Dalit leader Ram Vilas Paswan by their side. 'Except for Muslims, we had made inroads in all communities. You can call it a Hindu vote bank with a strong caste flavour,' is how one BJP leader described the party's Bihar strategy.

The Patna blasts only seemed to consolidate this 'Hindu' vote bank, with the needle of suspicion pointing at Islamic militant groups. Nitish was isolated and already appeared to wear a slightly defeated look when I met him for dinner in late 2013 at author-turned-JD(U) politician Pavan Varma's residence. With reports of a Modi mini wave blowing through Bihar and our election tracker showing him losing out, I asked him if he regretted breaking with the BJP. '*Kahan regret ki baat? Politics mein chunav hote*